

Surface Textures: The Ground and the Page

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PROLOGUE

THE LAST SEVERAL YEARS HAVE SEEN a remarkable revival of interest in surfaces, in my own discipline of social anthropology to be sure, but also in human geography, architecture and design, and in studies of literary, visual, and material culture.¹ What has unlocked this interest is also a certain unlocking of both the body and the earth—an ontological inversion, or a turning inside out—that has undone the modernist assumption that the true essence of things and persons is to be found deep inside them, in an inner core that can be reached only by breaking open the external appearance behind which it hides. It is this assumption that so often leads us to equate the surface with what is “superficial.”² It is why we distrust surfaces and the meanings they convey: why we think we have to break through them or peel them aside, if ever we are to arrive at real significance. Psychologists aim to penetrate behind the machinations of the body to discover the inner sanctum of mind; archaeologists dig deep into the earth in the hope of finding treasure-filled chambers; literary scholars plumb the depths of their texts to recover historically repressed meanings. But what if there is nothing underneath? What if surfaces are the real sites for the generation of meaning? Then by mining them, excavating them, or clearing them away, we may in fact be destroying precisely what we seek to find, and that lies under our very noses, convinced as we are that the truth can never be on the surface but somewhere deeper down.

In this essay I am concerned with two kinds of surface with which we deal at every moment of our everyday lives. They are the page and the ground. We encounter the page most often as the leaf of a book, or perhaps of an unbound manuscript or document, which is either blank or more or less covered in writing. We encounter the ground as a surface of support for our activities, a terrain either cleared for cultivation or building or inscribed with the traces of our passing such as footprints, paths, and tracks. My purpose is to compare the two. Is a blank page like cleared ground? Is there an analogy, even an equivalence, between walking the ground and writing the

page, or between following a trail and reading a text? I want to argue that for modern writers and readers, accustomed to a technology of print, the page is not what it was for the scribes of medieval times who wrote with quill on parchment, or for the readers of their handwritten works. But nor, I suggest, is the ground, for modern people, what it once was for medieval husbandmen who drew their living from the earth. My claim is that as surfaces, ground and page have analogous properties today, as they did in the past, but only because each has undergone a parallel historical metamorphosis. It is this metamorphosis that I attempt to capture here.

But I have one further aim. It is to find a way of restoring our literate imagination to our experience of inhabiting the earth. Just as the ground, in modernity, appears to set up a barrier between the material or earthly conditions of existence and the forms and meanings that the human mind projects upon them, so it seems that the page divides the literary expression of these forms and meanings from the world of which they tell. Are we fated, then, ever to read and write *about* a world whose substance hides from us, on the far side of the page? Does the very opacity of the page stand for the world's impenetrability? Or could we find a way of writing, and of reading, that enters into the very weave of the world, in the ongoing formation of its surfaces and textures? Could the page, like the ground, become a zone of habitation—a zone in which experience and imagination fuse? In this endeavor, I believe, we would come close to the most literal sense of geography as *earth writing*—a writing that is not *about* the earth, that does not seek to describe, copy, or represent the earth by means of words, but rather that writes *on*, *with*, or *through* the earth, driven by forces analogous to those that move its living inhabitants. The inspiration behind this idea comes from the monastic traditions of medieval Europe, and it is from these that I begin.

THE TREE AND THE BOOK

In the twelfth century the Parisian philosopher-theologian Hugh of St. Victor declared that “the whole sensible world is like a kind of book written by the finger of God.”³ This is one of the earliest known references to the idea of the book of nature, and it rested on a homology between the *word* of God (*verbum Dei*), in the composition of the scriptures, and the *works* of God, in the creation of the world and its creatures.⁴ In reading their liturgical texts, the monks of the time would reenact the performance of their composition, by tracing the inscribed lines with their fingers while murmuring the corresponding sounds, from which the words would once

again reemerge as if the page itself was speaking to them. Time and again, the monks would compare the meditative practice of reading to a process of wayfaring through the terrain. They would picture themselves as hunters on the trail, drawing on—or “pulling in”—the creatures they encountered, or the events to which they bore witness, along the paths they travelled. The Latin word for this drawing or pulling in was *tractare*, from which is derived the English “treatise” in the sense of a written composition. Surrounded by the voices of the pages as the hunter is surrounded by the sounds of nature, the medieval reader would listen to them, and take counsel from what they had to say.⁵

In our day, words like “reading” and “writing” make primary reference to the verbal arts; even the “book” is assumed to be a volume of words, set out on its pages. So when we speak of the book of nature, and of its interpretation, the assumption is that we are drawing an analogy from the world of letters, in which we are inclined to bury our heads, to the physical world in which we find our feet. The direction of analogical extension is from page to ground. But historically, it was precisely the reverse: from ground to page. The verb “to write” comes from Old Saxon *writan*, meaning to scratch, tear, or score.⁶ Thus in early medieval times, wherever on earth one found things incised, scratched, cut, or torn—things like animal tracks, split wood and ploughed furrows—there was writing. Only by extension did the word come to refer to the human act of incising marks in stone, and thence to the inscription of other kinds of surfaces, from parchment to paper. And only then did its meaning narrow from inscriptions of any kind to those that took the particular forms of letters. The hand that once had held the axe, the hoe, and the plow now held the pen. Thus the lines the husbandman or wayfarer would draw in the earth became lines of writing, and the surface of inscription was transposed from ground to page.

It was much the same with reading. The verb “to read” comes from the Old Saxon *ræd* and its Germanic equivalents, meaning to advise or take counsel. It is about listening to things. Someone who is “unread” has failed to pay proper attention; someone who is “ready” is well prepared from having done so. The object of reading then becomes a “riddle,” a term that is again derived from the same root. To the wayfarer, nature presents itself as a compendium of riddles, each of which must be solved if the journey is to continue. Thus the hunter reads the tracks, the woodsman the grain, the ploughman the furrow. Words, too, are riddles, and like the phenomena of nature, their meanings are often obscure. So it was that when the monks of medieval times applied the term “reading” to their practice of poring over manuscripts, they meant that the pages were as full of riddles as the

inhabited world, and that you could only carry on, and get closer to the truth of things, by paying attention to them, and to what they might reveal. Even trees spoke in riddles, pronouncing prophecies in the rustling of their leaves, none more so than the mighty oak and its relative the beech (in Old English, *boc*), from which the book takes its name.⁷ And every page of the book was a leaf. To read the book was to listen to the voices of the pages as one would listen to the rustling of leaves in the woods.

The tree and the book, then, were of a kind, and not just because of their whispering leaves. Before paper came into general use the wood from trees—especially the beech—was commonly used for writing tablets. And it was from trees, also, that writers obtained their ink. It came from the galls of the oak, crushed and boiled with a rusty nail. If the oak's prophecies were pronounced through its leaves, it is perhaps no wonder that they were written in the dissolution of its galls, or that this writing should be fixed with nails as the carpenter fixes planks and beams. But besides ink, of course, medieval scribes needed pen and parchment. The parchment began life on the backs of grazing animals—usually sheep, goats, or calves—and required intensive preparation prior to use. The pen came from a feather that had once graced a bird in flight, most often a goose or swan. Thus to bring pen to parchment was already to unite the elemental domains of sky and earth. Where sky meets earth lies the surface of the ground, a surface seasonally inscribed by the feet of the wayfarer or husbandman, or by the hooves of his flocks and herds, only to be wiped clean by wind, rain, and snowmelt before being inscribed once again, in the next season. It is the same with pen and parchment, and this brings me to the crux of the analogy between the ground and the page.

THE PALIMPSEST

Due to its expense and the labor of preparation, it was common for one parchment to be reused many times. Between each writing, it had to be cleaned of previous inky traces by scraping the surface with a penknife otherwise used for cutting the quill and scoring guidelines. The alternation of writing and scraping, writing and scraping, would continue until the material was so reduced as to be no longer usable. A parchment that bears the traces of successive reuse is known technically as a *palimpsest*. In what follows I aim to show that the cycle of inscription and erasure through which the palimpsest is formed precisely parallels that which sculpts the surface of the ground, and that this gives to both a quite distinctive character. The parallel has indeed been seized upon by archaeologists who have adopted

the palimpsest as a term by which to refer to a ground that, like a parchment, has borne the brunt of successive workings. In the early 1950s one of the originators of the analogy, Osbert Crawford, expressed it thus:

The surface of England is like a palimpsest, a document that has been written on and erased over and over again; and it is the business of the field of archaeology to decipher it. The features concerned are of course the roads and field boundaries, the woods, the farms and other habitations, and the other products of human labour; these are the letters and words inscribed on the land.⁸

All of England, for Crawford, is a work of earth writing! Setting aside the nationalist tenor of his remarks, I would like to draw attention to the paradox they embody, namely that it sets archaeologists to work in deciphering traces of a past that, by rights, should have already been erased by the present. That there is something left for them to work on is an index of the fact that the erasure is never complete, that something always remains. Once again, it is the same with the serially reused parchment. However hard you scrape with the knife, it is difficult to eliminate all vestiges of previous markings. But this reveals the palimpsest to be a surface of a very peculiar kind. I shall call it *antistratigraphic*. For it is built up not by adding layer upon layer but by taking layers away. In it, traces of the past rise to the surface even as those of the present sink into the depths. Thus if archaeologists really intended to read from the palimpsest the marks of earlier earth writings, then the last thing they should do is strip it down! For the effect of removing the uppermost layers would be to eliminate what faint traces of past inscription still remain.

Suppose, for example, that you are surveying a landscape for evidence of ancient trackways. The more ephemeral paths will have long since disappeared, wiped away by wind and weather, and by the effects of subsequent land use. But of the most heavily used tracks, which would once have cut deep grooves in the landscape worn by feet, hooves, and cartwheels, visible traces still remain. They appear as the shallowest of impressions, which it might take a trained eye to see. Yet all around you are the much more visible marks of recent and present activity, cutting deep into the earth. Centuries hence, maybe the deepest of these marks will still be visible on the surface, until they are eventually dissolved into the atmosphere. Once again, it is the same with the page as with the ground. It is because the writer's ink sinks deep into the parchment—becoming absorbed into its very substance—that the traces it leaves are so persistent. The deeper the absorption, the harder they are to erase. Palaeographers call the vestiges of earlier inscriptions preserved in parchment the *scripto inferior*, or “underwriting,” and what is overwritten the *scripto secunda*. But it would be closer to the mark to

say that the present underwrites what, of the past, is left over. It is not that the past shows up from below, through the semi-translucent surface of the present, but rather that the present penetrates the depths even as the past rises to the surface. Present and past, in short, are upside down. Such is the topsy-turvy, antistratigraphic character of the palimpsest.

To the modern mind this inversion is hard to grasp. Despite the metaphorical appeal of the palimpsest, archaeologists are still inclined to think of the earth as formed of successive strata, each of which covers over and, to an extent obscures, the one preceding. So too do scholars of many other disciplines, ranging from geology to history.⁹ It is as though, preparatory to every round of inscription—in a cycle of seasons, years, or ages—a fresh carpet were rolled out over the entire terrain, only to be buried by the next. Each round, then, belongs to its own time, and comes with its own inscriptions. And with every additional stratum the past, far from rising to the surface, sinks further down; you would have to peel away more recent accretions to find it. This, of course, is what archaeologists do when they excavate a site, disclosing successive horizons in reverse chronological order and, in so doing, unintentionally creating the palimpsest rather than revealing it.

Architects, too, while their objective may be to build rather than to excavate, are also prone to stratigraphic thinking, even when there are no actual structures to put up. For example, in his reflections on the aesthetic practice of walking, architectural theorist Francesco Careri refers, *inter alia*, to the work of artist and sculptor Richard Long. Notorious for walking straight lines first ruled on a cartographic map, Long writes the earth with his feet, which leave their mark in the trodden grass of a meadow or the stony ground of a mountain plateau. This is not about laying out a two-dimensional surface on which one can walk; indeed Long insists that what distinguishes his art is that it lies in the act of walking itself. Nevertheless, in commenting on Long's work, Careri does not hesitate to compare the ground surface to a vast canvas, "an immense aesthetic territory . . . on which to draw by walking." Each walk, he says, adds "one more layer."¹⁰ But how can a walk add a layer? The stratigraphic imperative of modern thought, it seems, has led Careri to recast the act of inscribing a line in a surface already laid bare by the elements as the rolling out of a surface already inscribed by line!

TWO SIDES OR ONE?

So what *is* the ground? How should we imagine it? We may surely agree, as a first approximation, that it is some portion of the earth's surface. But

this begs many questions. What kind of surface is this? How many sides does it have? Does it divide or unify? Does it cover or cover up? Must it be penetrated if we are to find what lies beneath?

One of the few to tackle these kinds of questions head-on was the founder of ecological psychology, James Gibson, in his pioneering work on visual perception.¹¹ For Gibson, surfaces are one of three components of the terrestrial environment; the other two are *medium* and *substances*. It is in the separation of medium from substances, Gibson surmised, that surfaces are formed. For us humans, the medium is the atmosphere: it allows freedom of movement, and, as a conductor of light, pressure waves, and olfactory molecules, it affords the possibility of vision, hearing, touch, and smell. Substances are of or pertain to the earth; being more or less solid they limit movement and perception but nevertheless afford support and nutrition for living creatures. All terrestrial objects, resting on the earth and surrounded by the atmosphere, have their surfaces, but all, too, bear upon the ground. As the fundamental surface on which all else rests, the ground figures in Gibson's account as "the reference surface for all other surfaces."¹² It is the primary interface between medium and substances, making it so that earth and atmosphere keep to their proper domains and do not mix.

With the palimpsest, however, this principle of separation is subverted. For far from dividing earth from atmosphere, the palimpsest emerges as a surface in their very fusion. It is where tracks, grains, and furrows in the earth, welling up from the depths, are laid bare by atmospheric forces of weathering and erosion that bear down from above. The ground as palimpsest is a blend of earth and atmosphere. Could the same be said of the page?

Ground and page, thus understood, are examples of what architectural design theorist Lars Spuybroek calls a "deep surface," formed of forces that operate, constitutively, from the inside out, and erosively, from the outside in.¹³ Such surfaces are both of inestimable depth and limitless in their atmospheric reach. To venture upon such a surface, as the wayfarer does, or the medieval reader of liturgical texts, is to inhabit an entire milieu. Spuybroek's inspiration comes from the writings of the Victorian social thinker and art critic John Ruskin. Introducing the fifth and final volume of his *Modern Painters*, published in 1860, Ruskin described the ground as a "veil of strange intermediate being." At bottom, Ruskin argued, the earth is dead and cold, but at its surface—in the textures of its meadows and forests, rocky outcrops, moor, and heath—it ministers to its inhabitants through this veil: "which breathes, but has no voice; moves, but cannot leave its appointed place; passes through life without consciousness . . ." ¹⁴ Perhaps we could follow Ruskin in thinking of the ground or the page as a veil of

intermediacy rather than a plane of separation. Ruskin himself began with the injunction: “To dress it and keep it.”¹⁵ Dressing, here, is an act of care, of looking after. The veil covers, but does not cover up; it is a revelation, not a disguise. It does not hide the depth *behind* the surface but allows us to feel the depth *in* the surface.

Might this account for what otherwise seems like a curious incongruity in the meaning of the verb “to wear”? It can refer to adornment, as in “wearing clothes,” and to erosion as in “wearing away.” In a stratified world, these meanings would be contradictory. It is one thing to add a layer, another to strip it off. But with the antistratigraphic principle of the palimpsest, epitomized in the Ruskinian veil, adornment and erosion become one and the same. Here, worn earth and worn parchment wear the veil of their wearing away. It is in the very erosion of substance, whether of earth or parchment, that the veil rises to the surface. It is “pressed out” of the material, as Spuybroek puts it, extruded from the interior rather than impressed from the exterior.¹⁶ The sculptors of classical times and their Renaissance emulators, who turned rough-hewn blocks of marble into human figures draped in velvet robes, would have known this. They did not dress up their stone, but through chiselling, grinding, and polishing, allowed the dress to emerge from it. But it is no different when we say of the worn face, wrinkled and ruddied by long exposure to sun and wind, that it wears its expression, of worn hands that they wear the folds and calluses from years of working with materials, or of ancient stone steps that they wear the patina of countless passing feet. And so too, it is the erasure of the palimpsest that reveals its text, and its texture.

One important consequence follows. As an antistratigraphic surface, the veil has only one side. There is no far side, beyond which lies naked flesh or bare earth. One can look *into* the veiled surface, but not *through* it. No nude figure lies behind the drapery of the marble statue to titillate the desire of the voyeur. But nor does the surface present an absolute barrier to vision. It is not the case, as literary scholars Stephen Best and Sharon Marcus maintain, that the only alternative to seeing *through* a surface is to look *at* it, as if it had length and breadth but no depth.¹⁷ We are not, in other words, forced to choose between a world draped in meaning and one stripped down to its bare materiality, or—as the language of modernity has it—between culture and nature. The veil, in short, is not an *interface*. By definition, according to philosopher Branden Hookway, the interface has two sides, interior and exterior, or upper and lower, and serves both to separate what is on one side from what is on the other, and as a conduit for the transmission of information across the threshold between them.¹⁸ For Gibson, as we have

seen, the ground was an interface in this sense, separating the substance of the earth from the medium of the atmosphere. But with the ground as veil or palimpsest, earth and atmosphere are folded into one another. The earth is not hidden beneath the ground; rather the ground *is* the earth's arising, its welling into life. By way of the ground, as Martin Heidegger put it, the earth "spreads out" into rock and water, "rises up" into plant and animal.¹⁹ Or to return to Ruskin, it is at the surface that the earth "ministers" to its inhabitants.

And so, too, in medieval times, the page would minister to its readers. Its text, welling to the surface, would reveal the words of God much as the textures of the ground—its rocks, vegetation, and trees—would reveal His works. Herein, as Hugh of St. Victor taught, lies the equivalence of words and works that grounds the idea of the book of nature. But if the page is akin to the ground, then it, too, can have only one side. Of a book, bound and closed on the shelf, this might seem an odd thing to say. Is the book not physically comprised of pages laid one over another to form a stack? If every page is a stratum, then the book itself would be tantamount to a stratigraphic assemblage. For medieval readers, however, the book was never closed but always lay open, in the scholar's hands or on his desk.²⁰ In an open book, you pass from page to page not by working your way down but by turning. To turn a page is like the wayfarer's turning a corner, or surmounting a pass, at which point a new vista opens up ahead. Where in a stack, every page has a front and back, or top and bottom, in the open book it has two faces, one of which is the reverse of the other, as verso to recto. Like the two faces of the mythical Janus, the page faces two ways, but there is no going through. For every page of the book is not so much a layer as a fold. In reading a book and turning its pages, one passes from fold to fold, opening each in turn only to close its predecessor behind you.²¹

THE ORIGINS OF STRATIGRAPHY

How come, then, that we—self-styled "moderns"—are so inclined to think of both the ground and the page in stratigraphic terms? The answer, I believe, lies in two technologies that did much to establish the particular character of the modern era, namely paving and printing. Both served to place life and letters on a hard and featureless foundation. Paving, for a start, was designed to cover the substantive earth with a layer of rigid and impenetrable material that would keep it where it belongs, below ground, and prevent it from having any intercourse with the air. For architects and planners of the modern city the rationale for paving was partly one of public health,

since the mixture of earth and air was commonly thought to give rise to noxious vapours, and partly one of improving the conditions of transport, allowing movement across the surface unimpeded by the perils of mud and swamp, scrub and forest, rocks and stones, that would formerly have encumbered the wayfarer.²² Paving places a lid on the rising of the earth from below, at the same time as it resists the erosive forces of the atmosphere, of wind and weather, from above. Unlike unpaved ground, paving did indeed establish an interface, with topside and underside, both keeping earth and air apart and allowing regulated transmission from one domain to the other, for example through drainage and sewage systems. And with the ground assumed by default to be paved, everything else—rather than rising from it—was supposed to rest upon it, as furniture rests upon the floor of an apartment, scenery on the boards of the stage, buildings on concrete foundations, or industrial plant on a production platform.²³

It was the same with printing. In the very principle of its operation, the press is stratigraphic, in that it works by overlaying one surface upon another. It is a meeting of preformed surfaces, not a constitution of surface in the meeting of substance and medium. Thus the press put an end to writing, understood as an act of scribing the page. In writing by hand on parchment, the pen would leave its mark in the material as the enduring trace of a manual gesture, much as a path is left in the ground in the wake of passing feet. The letterline of writing, like the trodden path, would continually emerge as a differential within the surface texture, while nevertheless remaining fully *of* that texture. It is not as if the line had lifted off onto a plane of its own, allowing the page or ground to sink back into blank homogeneity. That is why, to recall our earlier example, the feet of artist Richard Long do not, in fact, roll out a new layer over the terrain, as you might roll out a cartographic map, every time he takes a walk! The line of his walking is traced in the deep surface of ground, not layered over it. Or as philosopher Gilles Deleuze puts it, in his treatise on difference and repetition, the line distinguishes itself from the ground “without the ground distinguishing itself from the line.” Difference, in other words, is unilateral.²⁴

But with letterpress printing it is quite otherwise. For far from emerging from within the matrix of the surface, as text in texture, individual letters are preengraved in miniature blocks of metal, or “sorts,” which have first to be assembled in the galley before being inked and placed in the press. Here the labor of the scribe is preempted by that of the engraver and typesetter. Only after having been laid out in its entirety (albeit in mirror reversal) on the plane of the galley, is the composition then levered down from above upon the initially flat and featureless surface of the signature sheet. Thus

whereas handwritten letters are “pressed out” from the material of the page, printed letters are impressed upon it. “Typography,” as literary scholar Anna Reynolds puts it, “is now a digital process, with ink sitting on top of, rather than within, the surface of the page.”²⁵ Each letter is, in itself, a discrete fragment or particle, broken off from those preceding and following in the string of letters making up a line. The line, then, is not the trace of a movement or gesture but a connected sequence of verbal particles, or what linguists call a syntagm. And being *on* the surface rather than *in* it, the lettering is no more intrinsic to the page than the page to the lettering. Instead of the one unilaterally registering a difference within the other, they are bilaterally indifferent. Following Deleuze, we could speak of the “black indifference” of the letters to the page, and the “white indifference” of the page to the letters. In Deleuze’s vivid metaphor, letters are strewn across the page like scattered members, “a head without a neck, an arm without a shoulder, eyes without brows.”²⁶ But less anatomical comparisons could be drawn: with the arrangement of furniture on a floor, of props on the stage, of houses on an estate. Such is the character of the hard-surfaced world.²⁷

The transition, then, from manuscript culture to printing, and from earth walking to hard surfacing, was essentially one from the antistratigraphic to stratigraphy. Once again, we can take our cue from Deleuze, writing this time with his collaborator Félix Guattari, for whom the distinction between the principles of stratigraphy and antistratigraphy, as I have set them out here, comes down to that between the *tracing* and the *map*.²⁸ Unfortunately, however, Deleuze and Guattari confuse everyone, themselves included, by using these terms back to front. In a nutshell: what they mean by *mapping* is actually the formation of a trace, as in walking a path or handwriting a line; while what they mean by *tracing* is actually the vertical superposition of layers, as when a map is rolled out over the terrain. Nevertheless, even though they have the terms the wrong way around, the distinction holds. The logic of stratigraphy (mapping for us, “tracing” for Deleuze and Guattari) articulates and hierarchizes successive states of affairs, each of which comes ready-made, piling one upon the other like printed sheets in a stack, or like the successive levels of a tree-diagram that mediate between a deep structure below and a surface structure above. Antistratigraphic logic, by contrast, is rhizomatic: here the roots, like those of a real tree growing in the ground, rise up from the depths into the surface. To make a trace (“mapping” for Deleuze and Guattari) is then to join with, and to follow, the textures of the surface, as when walking a path or inscribing a line. It is “an experimentation in contact with the real.”²⁹ And meaning falls out of it.

REENTERING THE PAGE

Is it any longer possible, then, for us to reenter the page as we once walked the ground, to restore our literate imagination to our habitation of the earth? Or are we forever excluded from it? Can there be an earth writing in which stratigraphic and antistratigraphic principles are combined? “We will never have understood writing,” protests literary theorist Juliet Fleming, “if we continue to think in layers, for ‘on’ is only a special case of being ‘in’ the world.”³⁰ The ink of the printed page may be on top of, rather than within, the surface of the page, but the page nevertheless remains within, not on top of, the world itself. How then, might we simultaneously be *on* the page and *in* the world? I would like to conclude with two very different experiments to show how this might be done; there are doubtless many others. They proceed, however, in very different ways. In one example, words printed on the pages of a book serve, in effect, as notation for a performance, of reading aloud, in which the speaking body itself relives the experience of ground habitation. In the other example, both writing and reading blow apart the syntactic structures of the text, as wind and weather invade the structures of being, in such ways as to open up to a domain of affective resonance.

One of the finest pieces of contemporary earth writing I know is a popular children’s book, immortalized by the author Michael Rosen, with illustrations by Helen Oxenbury. It is called *We’re Going on a Bear Hunt*, and every page carries the same refrain:

We can’t go over it,
We can’t go under it.
Oh no!
We’ve got to go through it!³¹

Four children, their father, and the family dog are off to find the bear. On their way, they walk through long grass that goes “*swishy-swashy*” as they pass, through a deep river that goes “*splish, splosh*,” through wet, oozy mud that goes “*squelch, squerch*,” a dark forest where they go “*stumble trip*,” and a whirling snowstorm that howls “*hooo wooo*.” When the family does eventually come across the bear, everyone is so terrified that they run back home as fast as they can, bolt the door, and tuck themselves safely up in bed. The bear, once again starved of the company he craves, is left outside, lonely and forlorn, treading wearily back to his cave. It is an achingly sad story.

What makes it so poignant, however, is the way it is performed. As you read it, preferably aloud—as you mouth the words *splish, splosh, stumble trip* or *hooo wooo*—the earth and its weather reverberate in sound and feeling. Say the word *squelch*, and you can almost feel the ooze of wet mud

around your boots in the way your tongue scours the roof of your mouth, and hear the mud's suction in the sound it makes. This is not just a case of onomatopoeia. *Squelch* doesn't stand as a copy of the sound of mud-mired suction. The resemblance between the sounds is rather an outcome of their having been produced through analogous processes. *Squelch* is the sound of a voice that has absorbed the experience of wet mud into its very way of speaking. It is to speak *with* mud, not *about* it. And of course it is not just mud that you speak with, for wind, grass, running water, and tree roots also get into the sound of your voice. With every page, moreover, you remind your listeners that it *falls* to you to mouth these sounds. You are as bound, in reading, to the imperatives of the page as you are, in walking, to those of the ground; there is no shortcut. The ground of the story—a ground neither under nor over which you can go—is equivalent to the Ruskinian veil, a meeting of earth and atmosphere akin to the palimpsest, where the constitutive forces of the earth meet the erosive forces of weather.

Yet here's the paradox, for the book's pages are printed and its letters are of type. On the printed page, unlike the ground it describes, there is nothing to stop you from skipping from one place to the next. Page and ground, it seems, are not equivalent after all; they rather rest on opposite principles. How can that be? Any comprehensive answer to this question would of course have to take into account the fact that the text is vividly illustrated. Since the relations between text and image are not my current concern, however, and purely for the sake of argument, I shall cursorily set the illustrations to one side so as to concentrate exclusively on the words. What concerns me is the difference, and the relation, between reading a printed text and reading it *out*.

We have seen that medieval monks, in their reading, would trace the letters on the page with their fingers while murmuring the corresponding sounds. For them, fingering and murmuring were inseparable aspects of one and the same performance. It was almost as if the digits and the vocal cords were synchronized with each other. And the words would fall out from the performance: they were both felt and heard, but not so easily seen—especially when the text was written in *scriptio continua*, without word breaks. For modern readers of the printed word, by contrast, the text itself is neither felt nor heard. It is rather scanned by eye. But this scanning is not, in itself, part of the performance. Reading words is one thing; reading them *out* is another. And it is the separation of the latter from the former that establishes the script as a *notation*. Strictly speaking, you do not perform a notation; you perform *from* it. In classical music, for example, it is conventional to indicate a note to be played by means of a dot, positioned

on or between the ruled lines of the stave. On the score, the dot is silent, inert and self-contained. But in performance, it is drawn out into a sustained and vibrant line of sound. So it is too with letters. Thus each individual “o” in the phrase *hooo wooo* is punctual and inert, but in performance a string of o’s translates into a prolonged aspirant sigh, resembling that of the wind. In short, and unlike the literate wayfaring of medieval readers, the ground of the *Bear Hunt* is not enacted in tactile contact with the page, but recreated “off page” as a phenomenon of haptic and auditory experience.

But what if there is no performance? Suppose that we read a text silently, as we usually do these days with printed books. We are just reading the words; nothing more. Can we nevertheless inhabit the book’s pages as we inhabit the land? This brings me to my second example. In a recent study of writings and films from the Canadian Arctic, literary scholar Rebecca Fredrickson points to an ontological equivalence between land and page, and to the writing of both. She attributes the equivalence, however, to a specifically northern sensibility, rooted in the experience of inhabiting an environment characterized by marked seasonal variations in light and darkness, by extremes of warmth and cold, and by immense expanses of land, sea, and sky that are not always clearly differentiated. Her claim is that this sensibility underwrites what she calls a “northern textual ecology.” Let me cite one short passage from Fredrickson’s study which, I think, puts the claim in a nutshell and, at the same time, introduces the idea of what she calls “weather-writing”:

As a connected part of the flux of life, that is, the processes that *are* life, literature draws the forces of its physical environment—storms, sudden winds, rain, melting—into its compositions. All literature is a kind of weather-writing. It is not a mimetic reproduction of the weather, but a place of becomings where the material of language produces forces analogous to the weather.³²

Though Fredrickson’s ostensive concern is with weather writing and mine is with earth writing, in truth I believe they come to much the same thing. After all there can be no earth without weather, or weather without earth. Who can say where the blizzard ends and the snowfield begins, or draw the line between rainfall and mud, mist and mountain, wind and dune? In the ground veil, as we have seen, earth and weather merge and blend. So too, earth writing and weather writing must necessarily fold into one another.

I do however want to stress the distinction that Fredrickson insists upon here, between *mimesis* and *analogy*. Her point is that the affective forces that move the hand of the writer in the process of composition, or that infuse the soul of the reader in silently reliving the experience on the page, are of a kind with those that bear upon and impel wayfarers as they plant their feet

in the land. The book may appear to be a finished artifact, with all its letters and words syntactically joined up into well-formed sentences. But in the process of writing, and in the experience of reading, it is not like that at all. Fredrickson's point, if I understand her correctly, is that in the turbulence of writing and reading, the syntactic structure is blown apart, releasing both writer and reader—like the weather-beaten wayfarer of northern climes—into the ever-flowing currents of world formation. As Fredrickson puts it, “there are blizzards blowing through syntax.”³³ Our habitation of the page, as of the earth, is not so much performative as affective.

EPILOGUE

At stake, here, are ways of speaking of the mind. For these, too, have long drawn on parallels with both the ground and the page. Is the surface of the mind akin to a palimpsest, inscribed with memories, the deepest of which are the most recent, while those from further back in time rise to the surface and eventually melt into air? Or is it composed of a series of strata, each of which covers over and buries its predecessor? There is no doubt that medieval people, for whom the purpose of both reading and writing was above all to commit texts to living memory, would have taken the former view, while modern people, for whom the text serves as a record that *substitutes* for living memory, destined for deposition in the stacks of an archive, would be predisposed to the latter.³⁴ It is surely no accident that contemporary neuropsychologists speak of the mind-brain as offering a neural *substrate* capable of supporting all manner of cultural accomplishments. For them, it is hard surfaced like the earth. But what if we were to think of the ground of human culture as something more like the soft carpet of vegetation covering field and forest? In treading such a ground, writes philosopher Alphonso Lingis, “we do not feel ourselves on a platform . . . but feel a reservoir of support extending infinitely in depth.”³⁵ It is this depth of support, affording rootedness and growth, and not the hardness and rigidity of a surface which affords neither, that counts in this instance. Drawing an analogy with the carpeted ground, might we not liken the mind-brain—as do Deleuze and Guattari—to a field of grass?³⁶

You can see why Deleuze and Guattari prefer grass to trees. It is because their trees are not living specimens rooted in the ground, but dendritic diagrams that articulate a hierarchy of levels of resolution, from deep to surface structure. But to close my discussion, I think we could well return to the ancient analogy between the tree and the book, to the oak and the beech, their tangled roots threading the earth, their emergent trunks rising

to an equivalent tangle of branches and twigs in the canopy, their rustling and chattering leaves mingling with wind and weather. Perhaps the domain of mind could itself be compared to a dense patch of woodland. In writing and reading, then, we would not move *across* a hard, preformed surface, as boots on tarmac or as on-road vehicles. We would rather find or push our way *through* the ground and, in so doing, contribute to its ever-emerging texture. This is the kind of movement I have called wayfaring—a movement that seeks not to connect predetermined points or territories but rather, at every moment, to keep on going. It is not a form of being but a way of becoming. And it is along this way, perhaps, that we can find the real meaning of earth writing.

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NOTES

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- 1 See, for example, Glen Adamson and Victoria Kelly, eds., *Surface Tensions: Surface, Finish and the Meaning of Objects* (Manchester U. Press, 2013); Joseph Amato, *Surfaces: A History* (U. of California Press, 2013); Isla Forsyth, Hayden Lorimer, Peter Merriman, and James Robinson, guest editorial (thematic issue on surfaces), *Environment and Planning A* 45.5 (2013): 1013–20; Stephen Best and Sharon Marcus, “Surface Reading: An Introduction,” *Representations* 108 (2009): 1–21; Rebecca Coleman and Liz Oakley-Brown, eds., “Visualizing Surfaces, Surfacing Vision,” special section of *Theory, Culture and Society* 34.7–8 (2017); Michael Anusas and Cristian Simonetti, eds., *Surfaces: Transformations of the Body, Materials and Earth* (Abingdon: Routledge, forthcoming).
- 2 In the tradition of symptomatic reading, “the surface is associated with the superficial and the deceptive” (Best and Marcus, “Surface Reading,” 4). Daniel Miller has pointed to the relationship, in western philosophy, “between surface and lack of importance”; see his “Style and Ontology,” in *Consumption and Identity*, ed. Jonathan Friedman (Chur: Harwood Academic, 1994), 71–96.
- 3 Cited in Peter Harrison, *The Bible, Protestantism and the Rise of Natural Science* (Cambridge U. Press, 1998), 44.
- 4 See James Joseph Bono, *The Word of God and the Languages of Man: Interpreting Nature in Early Modern Science and Medicine* (U. of Wisconsin Press, 1995), 11.
- 5 Tim Ingold, “Dreaming of Dragons: On the Imagination of Real Life,” *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* n.s., 19.4 (2013): 740–41.

- 6 See Nicholas Howe, "The Cultural Construction of Reading in Anglo-Saxon England," in *The Ethnography of Reading*, ed. Jonathan Boyarin (U. of California Press, 1992), 58–79.
- 7 See Spike Bucklow, *The Riddle of the Image: The Secret Science of Medieval Art* (London: Reaktion, 2014), 43–44.
- 8 Osbert Crawford, *Archaeology in the Field* (London: Praeger, 1953), 51.
- 9 See Cristian Simonetti, "The Stratification of Time," *Time and Society* 24.2 (2015): 139–62.
- 10 Francesco Careri, *Walkscapes: Walking as an Aesthetic Practice* (Barcelona: Editorial Gustavo Gili, 2002), 150.
- 11 James J. Gibson, *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1979), 16–32.
- 12 Gibson, *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception*, 33.
- 13 Lars Spuybroek, *The Sympathy of Things: Ruskin and the Ecology of Design*, 2nd ed. (London: Bloomsbury, 2016), 57–58.
- 14 John Ruskin, *The Works of John Ruskin* (Library Edition), vol. 7, ed. E. T. Cook and A. Wedderburn (London: George Allen, 1905), 14–15.
- 15 Ruskin, *Works*, 13.
- 16 Spuybroek, *Sympathy of Things*, 57.
- 17 Best and Marcus, "Surface Reading," 9.
- 18 Branden Hookway, *Interface* (MIT Press, 2014), 4.
- 19 Martin Heidegger, *Poetry, Language, Thought*, trans. A. Hofstadter (New York: Harper and Row, 1971), 149.
- 20 On the difference between the open and the closed book, see Peter Candler, *Theology, Rhetoric, Manuduction, or Reading Scripture Together on the Path to God* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2006), 12.
- 21 Not much has been written on the phenomenology of turning. One exception is Craig Farrell, "The Poetics of Page-Turning: The Interactive Surfaces of Early Modern Printed Poetry," *Journal of the Northern Renaissance* 8 (2017), www.northernrenaissance.org/the-poetics-of-page-turning-the-interactive-surfaces-of-early-modern-printed-poetry/.
- 22 On paving the streets of London, see Miles Ogborn, *Spaces of Modernity: London's Geographies, 1680–1780* (London: Guildford Press, 1998), 91–104.
- 23 Tim Ingold, *The Life of Lines* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2015), 37–40.
- 24 Gilles Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, trans. P. Patton (Columbia U. Press, 1994), 29.

- 25 Anna Reynolds, “‘Such dispersive scattredness’: Early Modern Encounters with Binding Waste,” *Journal of the Northern Renaissance* 8 (2017), www.northernrenaissance.org/such-dispersive-scattredness-early-modern-encounters-with-binding-waste/.
- 26 Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, 28.
- 27 Ingold, *Life of Lines*, 45.
- 28 Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia*, trans. B. Massumi (London: Continuum, 2004), 13.
- 29 Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*, 13.
- 30 Juliet Fleming, *Cultural Graphology: Writing after Derrida* (U. of Chicago Press, 2016), 141.
- 31 Michael Rosen and Helen Oxenbury, *We’re Going on a Bear Hunt* (London: Walker Books, 1989).
- 32 Rebecca Fredrickson, “Orientations in Weather: A Northern Textual Ecology” (doctoral diss., U. of Alberta, 2015), 14.
- 33 Fredrickson, *Orientations in Weather*, 31.
- 34 On the distinction between writing as a record and as an instrument of memory, see Mary Carruthers, *The Book of Memory: A Study of Memory in Medieval Culture* (Cambridge U. Press, 1990).
- 35 Alphonso Lingis, *The Imperative* (Indiana U. Press, 1998), 14.
- 36 Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*, 17.

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